

Realme Buds Air 5

Brimming with features and surprisingly good sound

Realme recently launched the Realme Buds Air 5 alongside the more expensive Realme Buds Air 5 Pro model that we recently reviewed. Over the years, Realme has successfully built a formidable portfolio of audio products and the new Buds Air 5 series seems like an excellent new addition to it. So, let's see if the Realme Buds Air 5 – priced at ₹3,699 – is actually worth your money, or not.

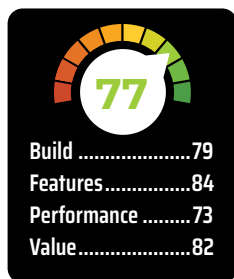
BUILD, DESIGN, AND FIT

The Realme Buds Air 5 features a cobble-shaped charging case with a matte finish that has a luxurious sheen on it. The material is resistant to fingerprints, however, it could get scratched easily, so maintain some caution when storing it. The case has the 'realme' branding on the front alongside an LED charging indicator.

At the bottom, you get a USB Type-C charging port and an inconspicuous pairing button. Upon opening the case, you see the black-coloured innards with the earphones tucked in snugly in their assigned slots. The front of the earbuds comes with handy L and R indicators as well. The charging case is extremely compact and will easily slip into small pockets and handbags.

The case can be opened one-handed with ease. There are magnets inside that help cradle the earbuds securely and the hinge is pretty solid for the price. The earphones are available in two colour variants – Deep Sea Blue and Arctic White. I got the latter for review, and I was quite impressed with the understated yet classy look.

The earphones also sport the same matte finish. They have elongated stems with touch sensors on the top part. These worked pretty well during my testing with



no instances of misreading, which is impressive. The buds are lightweight and fit snugly into my ear. Despite having no silicone wings for added support, these stayed put in my ears when I jogged or exercised. They come with an IPX5 rating, so they're fully protected against damage from sweat or splashes, making them a good option for your workouts as well.

FEATURES

The Realme Buds Air 5 are one of the most feature-laden pair of truly wireless earphones on the market under ₹4,000. Like its predecessor, the Buds Air 5 packs a bunch of premium features. Let me elaborate. These earbuds come with 50 dB Active Noise Cancellation – which is on the higher end of the spectrum at this price. The ANC performance is decent; it cuts out low-end sounds such as the hum of an AC or the drone of an airplane with relative ease, but noises such as traffic, car

horns, or human voices leak through. There's a Transparency Mode as well that amplifies ambient sound ensuring that you are aware of your surroundings. It works decently well, but it does sound a tad bit unnatural, so I hope Realme really works on this with the next iteration.

Users also get access to the Realme Link app. However, my review unit had quite a hard time connecting and staying connected to the app. There were several instances where the buds randomly disconnected from the app, and it would only fix itself if I disconnected and reconnected again. I hope realme smooths this over with an OTA update because the Realme Link app is possibly one of the most feature-rich accompanying apps at this price point.

There's basic stuff like checking the battery levels of your earbuds and charging case, performing firmware updates, and more. You can also change noise cancellation modes (Noise Cancellation, Off, or Transparency). There's a Smart Noise Cancellation option as well that adjusts the ANC level based on your environment, however, I don't think it made much of a difference when I used it, so I just deferred to using the Max Noise Cancellation setting.

You also get the option to customise the EQ using the 6-band equaliser that's available in the app. There are also presets such as Serenade, Original Sound, Pure Bass, and Deep Bass that you can choose from – it comes with Pure Bass active on default and that's what I used when testing the earbuds since most users will use it on default. There are also toggles for Dynamic Bass (which pumps up the bass response more) and Volume Enhancer.

You also get a Game Mode toggle that lowers the latency to merely 45 ms. This is very useful when watching OTT content or playing games. The app comes with an Earbud Fit Test as well to see if you've got a tight fit. Lastly, you can customise pretty much all the controls and realme has provided a ton of options here including Volume controls, which is rare!

App aside, the Realme Buds Air 5 also supports Dolby Atmos on select phones, Google Fast Pair, Bluetooth v5.3, and Smart